

THROUGH THE AGES

Literature

The first known female writer was Sumerian poet Enheduanna in the 3rd century BCE, but women's works in the English language did not appear until the 14th century. Women have since written prolifically across all genres—from simple recipes to novels, plays, and poems.



ALTHOUGH FEMALE WRITERS played a major role in Chinese, Korean, and Japanese literature from as early as 220 BCE (see pp. 74–75), women's writing did not flourish elsewhere until the advent of the printing press in the 15th century. It prospered further in the 1700s with the evolution of the novel and an increase in female readers, particularly in Europe. Writers such as Germaine de Staël and George Sand, infamous for wearing male clothing, wrote novels that explored the impact of social conventions on women. To reach a wider audience—or to ensure anonymity—some Western female writers resorted to male pseudonyms, even for novels

“**Everything** in life is **writable** about if you **have the ... guts** to do it.”

SYLVIA PLATH, POET AND WRITER, IN HER JOURNAL, 1950–1955

◀ Baroque girl genius

Miguel Cabrera's 1750 portrait of poet nun Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz shows her surrounded by books and writing materials.